



SISTER STEPHY HAS BEEN ARRESTED BY THE CBI IN CONNECTION WITH THE ABHAYA MURDER CASE

The Unholy List

- Arrest of a nun and two priests by the CBI in the case related to Sister Abhaya's murder.
- Sister Anoop Mary committed suicide due to her inability to bear torture by superiors.
- Excommunication of a nun from the church after an MMS of her indulging in sex with a male was circulated.
- A survey conducted by the church showed widespread discontent and dissatisfaction among the nuns.
- Plans of formation of a dissident congregation by some nuns after breaking away from the Congregation of the Mother of Carmels.
- State Women's Commission issues guidelines to end the widespread persecution and exploitation of nuns inside convents.
- More than 63 priests in Kerala face criminal cases.

their own favourites even when they were found guilty of moral or economic offences. "There was a huge gap between what they preach and practice. Most of the nuns and priests I have known used to have illicit sexual liaisons or were involved in serious corruption."

The most talked about episode in the book is Jesme's own sexual encounter with a priest when she was in her 30s. He embraced her forcibly, squeezed her breasts and undressed before her. She also admits that "as a young woman I was curious to see a male body that I have never seen". She has also written about the church's increasing affluence, anti-poor attitudes and also commercial-

ising its once lauded services in the education and health sectors. The proverbial last straw for Jesme was the alleged attempt from the leaders of her congregation to brand her as a mental patient and banish her from her job. "I was forcibly taken to psychiatrists. Then I knew my life was in danger and so had no option but to quit my job."

Jesme's open war against the church had endeared her to many including the Left parties which have a running battle against the church and clergy over many issues. "They have even offered me a seat in the coming elections. But I have decided to continue my fight against the wrong ways of the church alone.

Moreover, I am still with the church. All I want is to reform it from inside."

However Jesme's daring to take on the mighty church has already inspired others. A group of nuns belonging to CMC has revolted over the management of a school. The dissident nuns are planning to break away from CMC, unheard of in Kerala's Catholic Church. The SMC seems to be prepared for the snowballing storm. "Jesme and others prove the serious shortcomings which have crept into the complaint redressal system. If the complaints and dissatisfaction of members are not addressed, such eruptions could be natural," says Thelakat. Not so natural is the perversion that Jesme was forced to undergo. Her shocking story is certain to cause bigger ripples if it escalates into a political issue. There is no way the church can say Amen to her story.



“The church and congregation work in a world with all its attendant weaknesses. Sexual perversions or financial irregularities among priests and nuns are not new.”

FR PAUL THELAKAT, SMC's Spokesperson

For sister Jesme's interview, visit:
www.indiatoday.in/jesme

